Designing a Gamified Application for User Privacy Preference Extraction

Continual Assessment Report

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Abstract

[Write this after the main sections are drafted.]

Contents

1 Introduction **2**

1.1 Background 2

1.2 Project Objectives 3

1.3 Ideation of Solution 3

1.3.1 Review of Current Cookie Consent Practices 3

1.3.2 Requirements 6

1.3.3 Constructing the Solution 6

1.3.4 Constraints 6

2 Literature Review **7**

2.1 Review approach 7

2.2 Key themes 7

2.2.1 [Theme 1] 7

2.2.2 [Theme 2] 7

2.3 Research gap and implications for this project 7

3 Progress to Date **8**

3.1 Work completed 8

3.2 Design or investigation alternatives 8

3.3 Preliminary design or investigation 8

3.4 Challenges and risks 8

4 Research Plan for Next Semester **9**

4.1 Planned work and methods 9

4.2 Milestones 9

4.3 Evaluation and success criteria 9

5 Conclusion **10**

Chapter 1

Introduction

1.1 Background

Even in this day and age of absurd technological advancements, user privacy preference remains an alien topic for the general public. There are several ways user privacy preferences can be collected online, some common ways that are used may be through surveys [1], device settings parsing [2], and cookies' consent banner interaction [3]. This project will specifically be exploring how user privacy preferences are extracted through cookies, commonly presented to users with the interface of a popup provided by CMPs (Consent Management Platforms) called cookie banners [4] each time they visit a website.

Most people don't really pay close attention to the user privacy preferences that they (have to) set each time they visit a new website on the Internet and is presented with a cookie banner. Whenever people are presented with a popup-like interface with verbose texts that they have to read through, the instinct for most people would be to get rid of the popup window. As such when combined with the assumption that the general public isn't sufficiently educated on the topic of the importance of user privacy preferences and how to manage them well, users tend to click the options presented on the interface that allows them to proceed immediately (i.e. usually the "Accept All" or "Deny All" options). Some reasons why people tend to ignore how user privacy preference extraction works in cookie banners is likely driven by the cookie banners' deliberately complex design and users' knowledge limitations [5].

In view of this problem presented and potential causes that are established, this project aims to solve this issue by gamifying the process of user privacy preference extraction through cookie banners.

1.2 Project Objectives

Given the background of the project, the project aims to address the problems through primarily 3 objectives:

1. Investigate existing solutions that attempts to address similar issues
2. Design a solution that presents the management of cookies in a gamified interface
3. Evaluate how a gamified process may be effective in helping users manage their privacy preferences within their own initiative

With these 3 objectives as the foundational directive pointers for this report, the report will be detailing how the solution for this project came to ideation, the project's progress so far and it's subsequent analysis on how effective it is in achieving the objectives.

1.3 Ideation of Solution

Before constructing the ideation of this project's solution, it is useful to understand where the current common practices stands, specifically how do most websites collect user's cookies consent preferences.

1.3.1 Review of Current Cookie Consent Practices

As mentioned briefly in the introduction of the report, most websites currently uses specialized tools called Consent Management Platforms (CMPs) to help them log user's consensual choices for cookies that their websites will be using [6]. In the form of popups, user will be asked to indicate their preferences whenever they visit a website that their browser does not have cached data recording their privacy preference choices for the cookies.

Exhibit A: F1 Official Website

We will be taking the F1 official website [7] as an example of how this looks practically. Upon entering the website for the first time, users are greeted with the popup window shown in Figure 1.1.

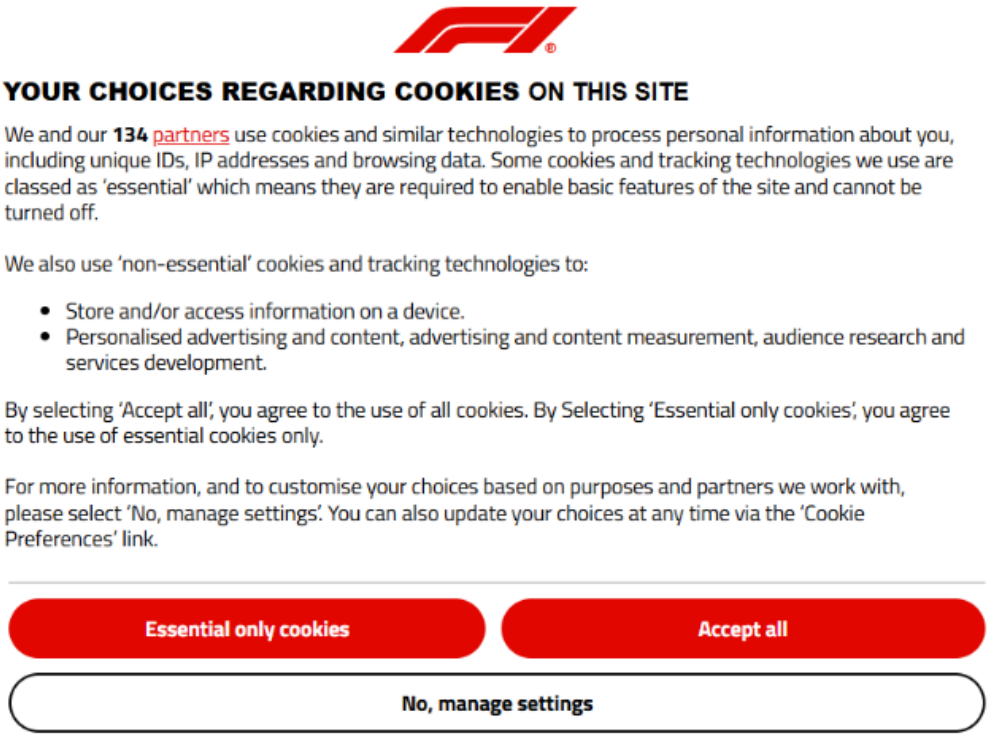


Figure 1.1: Cookie consent banner displayed on the F1 official website.

Users are presented with mainly 3 choices on the interface, one to accept only essential cookies, one to accept all, and the last one is to have more autonomy and manually manage settings for cookie consent choices. Observe how even though details regarding the cookies and what they are mainly used for is explicitly written on the interface, it is presented in a way that may seem overly verbose and irrelevant for the common public to understand. In addition, the options that are highlighted in red will also appeal more towards the user, which causes users to make choices that subject themselves to consent more cookies. This is a common practice among most websites known as dark patterns, that attempt to use manipulative UX designs to force user into making choices that often benefits the company behind [8].

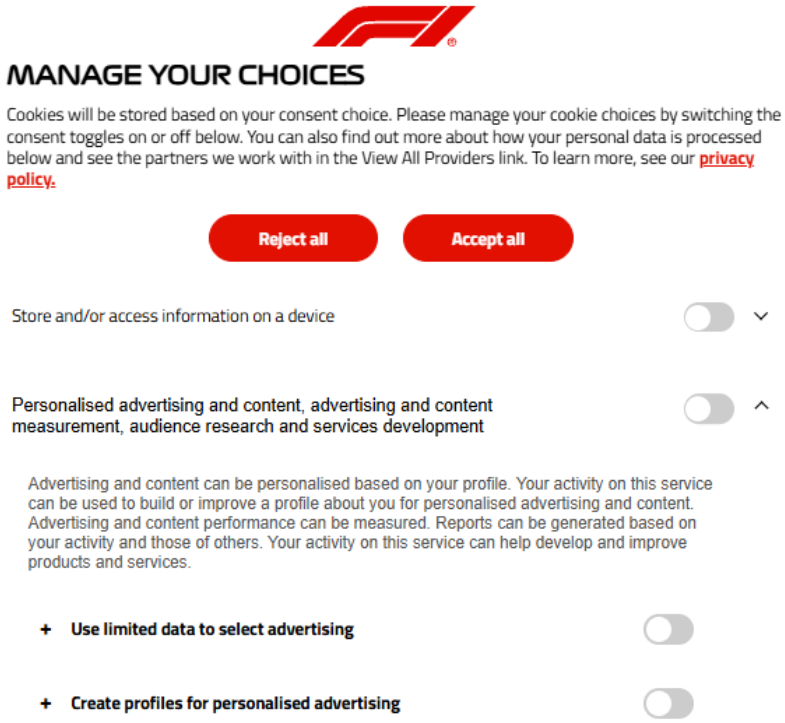


Figure 1.2: Cookie banner 'manage settings' window of F1 official website.

Upon clicking the 'No, manage settings' option, user can further indicate their preference for which purpose their collected data from the cookies can be used. The usage of cookies are split into different ways data collected through cookies can be used, such as to select advertising, or to create profiles for personalised advertising, as shown in Figure 1.2. Though the user is able to have more autonomy, this also adds to the problem of a complex privacy preference extraction process as user has to go through each options to decide whether they want to consent to it or not.

Exhibit B: Fifa Official Website

Another example that we can look at is from the Fifa Official Website [9]. Similarly, they have a cookie banner for the user to indicate their privacy preference through 3 buttons as shown in Figure 1.3.



Figure 1.3: Cookie consent banner displayed on the Fifa official website.

If the user were to click the preference center option marked in white, the user would then be greeted with another interface as such under Figure 1.4. Cookies that can be consented such as functional cookies are all compiled into one window in the privacy preference center interface. This may seem easier for the users to customize their privacy

preference, it took away some autonomy from the user when they can't consent at a deeper level where they consent only to certain functional cookies instead of all functional cookies as a whole, comparatively to F1's cookie banner in Figure 1.2 where user is able to indicate preference for each cookies' purpose. However, this is significantly more concise and easy for the user to go through.

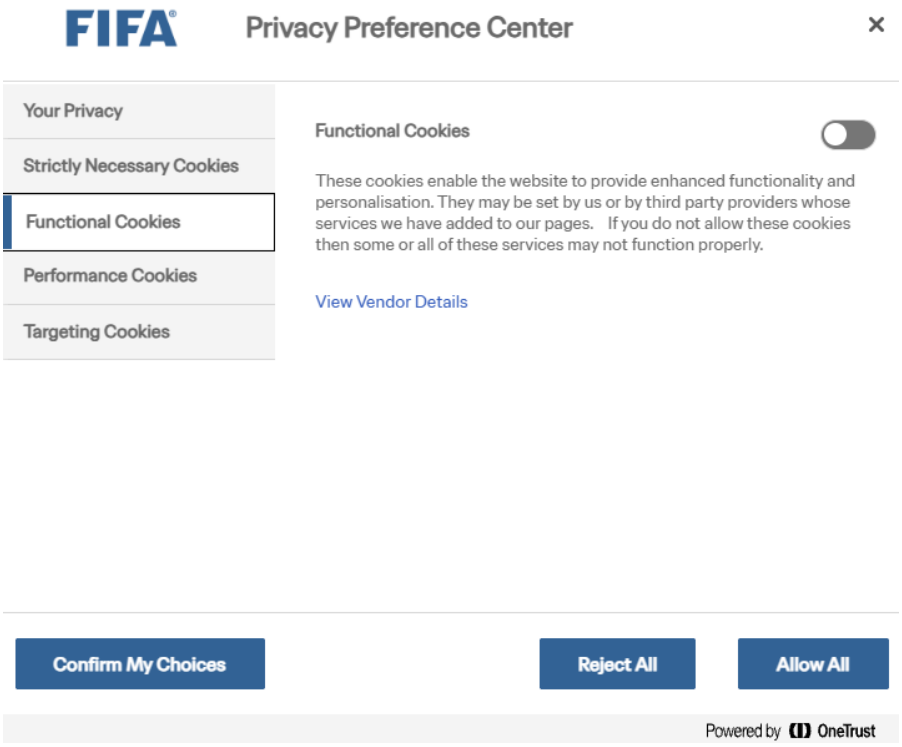


Figure 1.4: Privacy Preference Center of Fifa official website.

1.3.2 Requirements

1.3.3 Constructing the Solution

Addressing the Requirements

1.3.4 Constraints

Chapter 2

Literature Review

2.1 Review approach

[Describe where and how you searched, search terms, date range, and how you selected sources.]

2.2 Key themes

2.2.1 [Theme 1]

[Compare and synthesize relevant studies; do not just summarize one paper per paragraph.]

2.2.2 [Theme 2]

[Explain agreements, differences, limitations, and what remains unresolved.]

2.3 Research gap and implications for this project

[Show how the reviewed work motivates your objectives and design choices.]

Chapter 3

Progress to Date

3.1 Work completed

[Describe completed investigation, requirements, implementation, or other evidence of progress.]

3.2 Design or investigation alternatives

[Present plausible alternatives and compare them against clear criteria. A table can help.]

Table 3.1: Example comparison of alternatives (replace with your own).

Criterion	Alternative A	Alternative B
[Criterion]	[Evidence / trade-off]	[Evidence / trade-off]

3.3 Preliminary design or investigation

[Describe the current preferred direction, why it was selected, assumptions, and open questions.]

3.4 Challenges and risks

[Explain issues encountered and what you did or will do about them.]

Chapter 4

Research Plan for Next Semester

4.1 Planned work and methods

[List the remaining activities, methods, tools, and expected outputs.]

4.2 Milestones

Table 4.1: Provisional next-semester plan. Replace weeks with actual dates.

Period	Activity	Output
Weeks 1–2	[Refine design / protocol]	[Approved plan]
Weeks 3–5	[Build / collect / investigate]	[Intermediate result]
Weeks 6–8	[Evaluate / analyze]	[Evaluation findings]
Weeks 9–12	[Refine and write up]	[Final report / demonstration]

4.3 Evaluation and success criteria

[State how you will judge whether objectives have been met and what evidence you will collect.]

Chapter 5

Conclusion

[Briefly recap the problem, progress, current direction, and immediate next steps.]

References

[1] H. Asif and J. Vaidya, "A study of users' privacy preferences for data sharing on symptoms-tracking/health app," in *Proceedings of the [conference name]*, Nov. 2022, pp. 109–113. DOI: 10.1145/3559613.3563202

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